POLITICS | Monologues

IDEAS OF INDIA: On Hindutva and New India

SMRITI IRANI *Union minister of women and child development and minority affairs*

MINORITY REPORT



Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH

In her opening remarks, Union minister Smriti Irani mentioned the 'Hindu rate of growth', a 1970s term that was essentially used to describe the almost stagnant Indian economy, while drawing an analogy from the Hindu faith which was seen as stagnant, content and in need of reform. She said that her way of life revolved around '*sarva dharma sama bhava*' while also listing the various initiatives of PM Modi in the form of Jan Dhan, subsidised foodgrains, building of toilets and Ayushman Bharat as characteristic of New India. She reiterated that the schemes did not differentiate on the basis of caste or religion. On the Hinduism versus Hindutva debate and her role as the minority affairs minister, Irani talked of how it was incumbent on all to ensure feelings of segregation do not rise in the country. She also talked about the New Education Policy and her great privilege of writing the foundational document for it. She said for the first time in 30 years, the new document talks about a gender inclusion fund which she argued would also serve the academic needs of minority girls and women. Irani also talked about how she fought to get a female chair for the IIT Council when she was education minister and doing away with the VIP quota for Hajjis. ■

> **One has to be cognisant of the fact that when PM Modi speaks about Ayushman Bharat, does it not encompass all communities? When he builds homes for the poor, does it not have homes for minority communities?**

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Ayushman Bharat has ensured that 310 million Indians received free cancer screening; 170 million women were screened for cancer of the cervix and breast
- Democracy is not in peril; the Congress party is. Those who perish cannot subjugate the aspirations of India and connect it to their own political aspirations
- One needs to recognise that the term minority is not a term that is individualised only to one religion
- The new India provides close to 90 million women in self-help groups credit worth $32 billion (Rs 2.6 lakh crore) every year. That is the new India one must be proud of